

Session 28: From Shem to Abraham

Key Takeaways

- Out of the scattering judgment on Babylon, God brings the promise of a blessing for the whole Earth.
- Genesis 12 starts the cycle again, with Abraham and Sarah standing in as our new Adam and Eve.

From Shem to Abram: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 11:10-26

Prologue

¹⁰ These are the generations of Shem.

First Generation

Shem was one hundred years old, and he caused the birth of Arpachshad two years after the flood;
¹¹ and Shem lived five hundred years after he caused the birth of Arpachshad,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

Second Generation

¹² And Arpachshad lived thirty-five years, and he caused the birth of Shelah;
¹³ and Arpachshad lived four hundred and three years after he caused the birth of Shelah,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

Third Generation

¹⁴ And Shelah lived thirty years, and he caused the birth of of Eber;
¹⁵ and Shelah lived four hundred and three years after he caused the birth of Eber,
and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

Fourth Generation

¹⁶ And Eber lived thirty-four years, and he caused the birth of Peleg;
¹⁷ and Eber lived four hundred and thirty years after he caused the birth of Peleg,

and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

Fifth Generation

¹⁸ And Peleg lived thirty years, and he caused the birth of Reu;

¹⁹ and Peleg lived two hundred and nine years after he caused the birth of Reu, and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

Sixth Generation

²⁰ And Reu lived thirty-two years, and he caused the birth of Serug;

²¹ and Reu lived two hundred and seven years after he became the father of Serug, and he had other sons and daughters.

Seventh Generation

²² And Serug lived thirty years, and he caused the birth of of Nahor;

²³ and Serug lived two hundred years after he caused the birth of of Nahor, and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

Eighth Generation

²⁴ And Nahor lived twenty-nine years, and he caused the birth of Terah;

²⁵ and Nahor lived one hundred and nineteen years after he caused the birth of Terah, and he caused the birth of sons and daughters.

Ninth Generation

²⁶ And Terah lived seventy years,

Tenth Generation

and he caused the birth of of Abram, Nahor and Haran.

Genesis 11:10-26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

This genealogy in Genesis 11:10-26 is recursive because it backtracks to Shem to restart his line, from 10:21-31, which had split at Peleg and Joktan in the fifth generation. This genealogy provides a frame around the rebellion of Babylon and the scattering narrative. However, its literary form also imitates the ten-generation genealogy from Adam to Noah because it acts as a frame around all of Genesis 5:1-11:26.

Genesis 5:1-32		Genesis 10:1-32		Genesis 11:10-26	
Vertical Genealogy	Sons of God + the Flood	Horizontal Genealogy	Babylon + the Scattering	Vertical Genealogy	
This is the scroll of the generations ... (5:1)		These are the generations ... (10:1)		These are the generations ... (11:10)	
10 generations From Adam to Noah Ends with 3 sons		From Noah to 70 nations Noah's 3 sons		10 generations From Shem to Abram Ends with 3 sons	
The chosen line		The non-chosen lines		The chosen line	
Babylon Cities. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).					

The literary form of the genealogy matches closely with the genealogy in Genesis 5 but without the death notice (“and he died”) for each generation. Notice that this death formula has been supplied in the OG and Samaritan Pentateuch versions of this genealogy (καὶ ἀπέθανεν / וימת).

Instead of emphasizing death through repetition as in chapter 5, this genealogy emphasizes birth and multiplication, leading to the one generation who is barren—Sarah in [Genesis 11:30](#).

The genealogy of the sons of Noah sits in the middle of this large text block, which links together the 10 generations from Adam to Noah (Gen. 5) and the 10 generations from Shem to Abram (Gen. 11:10-27). This is the main thread of the narrative focus, which traces the seed of the woman from Genesis 3:15.

The genealogy in the middle of this sequence (Gen. 10) is the Table of Nations from the sons of Noah. This text traces the non-chosen lineage of Noah’s three sons—Japheth, Ham, and Shem—and their lines up to the division between Joktan and Peleg. On either side of the non-chosen lines are the rebellious disasters of the flood generation (Gen. 6-9) and Babylon (Gen. 11:1-9). These low moments in the story are framed by God’s preservation and gracious selection of one human line that will bear the promised seed.

Journey From Babylon to Canaan Part 1: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 11:27-12:5

Introduction

²⁷ Now these are the generations of Terakh.

Part 1: Terakh's Journey

Death and Barrenness in Ur-Kasdim

- a **Terakh** caused the birth of **Avram**, **Nakhor** and **Haran** ;
a' and Haran caused the birth of **Lot** .
b 28 And **Haran died before his father Terakh**
c in **the land of his family**,
c in **Ur of the Chaldeans** .
- a 29 And **Avram** and **Nakhor** took wives for themselves,
b **the name of Avram's wife was Sarai** ;
c and **the name of Nakhor's wife was Milkah**,
c' the **daughter of Haran**, the father of **Milkah** and Iskah.
b' 30 **And Sarai was barren, she had no child** .

Terakh Takes His Family

- 31 **And Terakh took (ויקח תרח...)**
Avram his son
and Lot , the son of Haran, the son of his son,
and Sarai his daughter-in-law, his son Avram's wife;

They Go Out of Ur To Enter Canaan but Don't Reach It

- and they went out** with them from **Ur of the Chaldeans**
in order to go to the land of Canaan ;
and they went as far as Haran, and they settled there.

Terakh Age + Death in Haran

- 32 And **the days of Terakh were five years and two hundred years**;
and Terakh died in Haran .

Part 2: Avram's Journey

Blessing and Children in the Promised Land

- 12:1 And Yahweh said to Avram,
a "Get yourself going
b **from your land**,
b' and **from your family**,
b' and **from your father's house** ,
a' to the land which I will show you.

- a 2 **And I will make you a great nation** ,
 b and I will bless you,
 a' and I will make your name great;
 b' and so you shall be a blessing.
 a 3 And I will **bless**
 b **those who** **bless** you,
 b' and **the one who** treats you as **cursed**
 a' I will **curse**;
 a and in you all the **families of the land**
 b will find blessing."

Avram's Age + Exit From Haran

4 And Avram went just as Yahweh spoke to him, and Lot went with him,
 and **Avram was five and seventy years** **when he went out from Haran** .

Avram Takes His Family

5 **And Avram took** (**ויקח אברם**)
Sarai his wife and Lot the son of his brother
 and all their possessions which they possessed
 and the people whom they had acquired in Haran,

They Go Out of Haran To Enter Canaan and Do Reach It

and they went out
in order to go to the land of Canaan
and they went the land of Canaan.

Genesis 11:27-12:5. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Notice how this two-step journey is also a two-generation journey. Abram completes what Terah begins, but only because of the word of God that comes to Abram.

Terah's journey begins with two tragic notes: Haran's death and the barrenness of his daughter-in-law Sarai. Sarai's infertility also highlights the contrast between her and her sister-in-law Milcah. They both have royal names ("princess" and "queen"), but Milcah's identity is described in terms of her family relations, while Sarai's identity is described only in relation to her inability to have children.

Terah's journey begins with these tragic notes and then moves in a three-stage process from (1) "taking," to (2) "going out," to then (3) arriving in Haran where Terah dies. Terah's journey begins with Haran's death and ends with his own death in another Haran.

Abram's journey begins with a recall of the two tragic notes that began Terah's journey. He is to leave his family and father's house (marked by death), and God will make him a great nation (thus reversing Sarai's infertility).

Not only will God reverse the tragedies of his family of origin, but he will also bring about an abundant Genesis 1 blessing that will flow out from him to the other families of the nations.

Once Abram has received this divine word of blessing that reverses his father's fate, he begins his own three-step process of (1) "taking," (2) "going out," and then (3) arriving in Canaan.

Abram's Journey: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 12:6-9

Avram's Sojourn to Shechem

- a 6 **And Avram passed through (ויעבר) in the land**
- b **unto the** place of Shechem
- b' **unto the** oak of Moreh,
- a' and the Canaanite was then **in the land**.

Worship + Altar for Yahweh

- a 7 And **Yahweh appeared to Avram** and he said,
- b "To your seed I will give this land."
- a' And **he built there an altar to Yahweh who appeared to him**.

Avram's Sojourn to Bethel

- a 8 **And he moved on (ויעתק) from there**
- b to the hill **from the east** of **Bethel**,
- a' and he spread out his tent,
- b' **Bethel** on the west
- b' and Ai **from the east**;

Worship + Altar for Yahweh

- a and **he built there an altar to Yahweh**
- a' and **he called upon the name of Yahweh**.

Avram's Sojourn to the Negev

- a 9 **And Avram journeyed (ויסע),**
- a' continually **journeying (נסוע)** to the Negev.

Genesis 12:6-9. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

Abram completes the journey that his father began when he finally arrives in Canaan. Notice how the scenes alternate precisely between three journey stages. The three stages are punctuated by two stops in Shechem and Bethel, where Abram builds altars and worships Yahweh, who called him and his family out of Ur of the Chaldeans.

A Tale of Two Sojourns

The text of Genesis 11:1-12:9 presents the stories of Babylon and Abram as two parallel journeys. One ends in rebellion and disaster, the other begins with disaster and ends in blessing.

Genesis 11:1-9 A Sojourn Into Disaster	Genesis 11:27-12:9 A Sojourn Into Blessing
Begins with “all the land ... journeying (נסע) from the east (מקדם)” [11:1-2] Concludes with “all the land” being “scattered” (נפוץ / הפיץ) [11:9]	Begins with one family leaving (ויצאו) the place of scattering, Ur of Chasdim [11:31] Concludes with Avram “journeying” (נסע) into Canaan in places “from the east” (מקדם) [12:8-9]
They find a “plain in Shinar” and “they settled there” (וישבו שם) [11:2]	They come to Haran and “they settled there” (וישבו שם) [11:31]
“Let us build (בנה) for ourselves a city and tower” [11:4] “... the city and tower which the sons of ‘adam built (בנה) for themselves” [11:5]	“and Yahweh said” (ויאמר יהוה) [12:1] followed by a reversal of circumstances — from barrenness to birth
“Let us make a name (שם) for ourselves” [11:4]	“I will make great your name (שם) [12:2]
“and Yahweh said” (ויאמר יהוה) [11:6] followed by a reversal of circumstances — from building to scattering	“and [Avram] built (בנה) there an altar to Yahweh” [12:7] “and [Avram] built (בנה) there an altar to Yahweh and he called upon the name (שם) of Yahweh.” [12:8]
A westward sojourn that ends with settlement by humans who use their potential for their own name, so that Yahweh becomes the antagonist and reverses their circumstances	A westward sojourn that ends with settlement by humans who have no potential to make a name for themselves, so that Yahweh becomes the protagonist and reverses their circumstances
Tale of Two Sojourns. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

Reflection Question

What are your biggest takeaways from this class?